

Leveraging Transformative Justice in Organizing Collective Action Towards Community Safety

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ABSTRACT

Criminologists and sociologists have documented the ways that technologies for community safety can perpetuate structural racism. Among these include policing technologies that encode Black criminality [4] and surveillance technologies which extends the reach of the carceral state [17]. Fortunately prior work in HCI has also investigated how the design of technologies for community safety can resist structural racism by employing strategies that stand as alternatives to traditional policing activities, including story-telling, community-building, and care practices [10, 11, 25, 27]. This body of work amplifies the practices of community organizations and employs their expertise to build safer community. I contribute to this body of research and ask how technologies can empower a layperson in the goal of building safer communities. This is an area of great potential— just as community policing technologies extend the reach of traditional policing, new technologies can be designed to extend the reach of community organizations aiming to dismantle oppressive social structures. Towards this goal, I leverage Transformative Justice (TJ), a community-based approach to addressing violence which asks us to not only examine the ways in which our current systems, structures, and norms perpetuate harm, but to also dismantle and replace those systems so that the conditions that enabled the harm are transformed. In this paper, I describe the current state of research, the principles of TJ, my goals for the PhD, and where I would benefit from further support.

CCS CONCEPTS

• **Human-centered computing** → **Empirical studies in HCI**.

KEYWORDS

crime, safety, justice, transformative justice, restorative justice

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1 BACKGROUND

HCI research on crime and safety has investigated how technology can support community policing. A popular definition of community policing by criminologist Andy Myhill describes it as a “*process of enabling participation of citizens and communities in policing at their chosen level, ranging from providing information and reassurance, to empowering them to identify and implement solutions to local problems and influence strategic priorities and decisions*” [21]. Prior work includes research on the use of social media platforms by the police to engage residents in crime-prevention efforts [9, 24], and the development of technologies such as CampusWatch, a smartphone application that arms students with GPS tracking, continuous video capture, and direct calls to campus security [23], ClearPath, a website created by the Chicago police to stimulate engagement amongst city residents [19], and a digital neighborhood watch which monitors the neighborhood by connecting the surveillance cameras of multiple households [5]. Other examples of crime and safety technologies include crowdsourced incident reporting systems, including CrowdSafe, a crime incident reporting and traffic routing application [26] as well as SALUS, a city-wide incident reporting and alert system are notable exceptions [16]. Evaluation of these technologies illustrates benefits, such as strengthened ties between police and citizens, enforcement of social norms, increased engagement of the local community in civic affairs, a more robust sense of safety for users, and increased awareness of local crime [9, 18, 19, 24].

At the same time, criminologists and sociologists have documented the ways that technologies used to support community safety can perpetuate structural racism. Among these include technologies that encode Black criminality [4], social media platforms like Nextdoor where discussions about “suspicious persons” serve as ways to establish radicalized norms of who does and does not belong in the neighborhood [17], and surveillance technologies like Amazon Ring which extend the reach of the carceral state, which is historically oppressive to people of color [1, 17]. Fortunately prior work has also investigated how technologies for community safety can be designed to resist structural racism. Dickinson and colleagues, for example, have designed a mobile application that amplifies the work of street outreach workers, to build a counter-structure to traditional policing [10]. This work and others employ strategies such as storytelling [10, 11, 25], relationship-building [10], and care practices [10, 27] as strategies to prevent violence. Researchers in this space have collaborated with community organizations and employed their expertise to counter oppression and build safer communities. However, there is less prior work on how technologies may organize collective action and empower a layperson in this endeavor. This is an area of great potential— just

as community policing technologies extend the reach of traditional policing, new technologies can be designed to extend the reach of community organizations aiming to dismantle oppressive social structures. Technologies used by mutual aid organizers to build capacity within communities to address material needs and the underlying political, economic, and social causes of these needs offer one such example [28]. These technologies, including Zoom, Slack, and Airtable, have enabled incredible collaboration and the creation of new social networks during the Covid-19 pandemic, but have also created barriers to participation for vulnerable populations [8]. Unity Philly, a smartphone application that facilitates community responses to opioid overdoses, offers an example of how mutual aid platforms can be designed to include vulnerable populations [20]. I aim to leverage the principles of Transformative Justice to contribute to this growing body of work.

Transformative Justice (TJ) is a community-based approach to addressing violence which asks us to not only examine the ways in which our current systems, structures, and norms perpetuate harm, but to also dismantle and replace those systems with community-based alternatives so that the conditions that enabled the harm to occur in the first place are transformed. Activist and writer adrienne maree brown describes how TJ seeks to go “*all the way down to the root system of the harm*” by critically examining the intersecting roles of economics, identity, and politics in relation to an incident of harm [3]. At the minimum, TJ seeks to respond to violence in a way that does not perpetuate more violence—TJ does not rely on systems like the prison industrial complex and also does not rely on systemic forms of violence like racial stereotypes, gender stereotypes, or vigilantism [3]. Transformative justice sees an individual’s liberation as tied to collective liberation and seeks to use a violent incident as an opportunity to dismantle the systems, structures, and norms that created the circumstances for the violence to occur [12]. The community is responsible for proactively building the infrastructures and practices that attain justice through accountability and connection. Transformative justice seeks to hold those who have perpetrated crimes accountable, but does not see anyone as the “enemy”; it acknowledges the humanity within those who have committed harm [22].

Ruth Morris, a Quaker who first coined the term “transformative justice”, initially discussed it with respect to crime. She sought to incorporate the recognition that our current conceptualization of crime ignores underlying socioeconomic wrongs and structural causes: crime, she explained, is “*an attempt to find power by the powerless and a negative response to pain by those in pain*” [7]. Scholar-activist Anthony Nocella II provides an example of the kinds of questions TJ might ask in order to understand what needs to be shifted in order to prevent the harm from occurring again: “*For instance, if a 14-year old boy who is queer and from a poor neighborhood robbed a store when it was closed at 2:00 a.m., transformative justice would not only look at the crime of burglary, but why the boy did it. Was the boy kicked out of his home by a father who was homophobic? Did the boy need money for food, clothes, and shelter?*” [22]. Our society marginalizes those who are poor and queer, hence there are two victims in this scenario- the owner of the store who was robbed and the 14-year old boy who is a victim of wider systemic injustices. This is an example of how TJ can be used to break down binaries of “victim” and “perpetrator”. TJ focuses our attention on

Table 1: Demographic Characteristics of Citizen Users

Phase 1: Identification	Phase 2: Imagine and Design	Phase 3: Evaluation
Goal: Identify the affordances in local crime and safety technologies that may exacerbate harm Approach: Qualitative research with users of the Citizen app. We will investigate three research questions: RQ1) What are the safety concerns and needs of users of the Citizen app?; RQ2) How do users’ perceptions of their communities and their community members evolve as they use Citizen?; RQ3) What are the features and affordances that contribute to changes in these perceptions? Methods: Interviews and surveys Data: Interview transcripts, survey responses Outcomes: Empirical analysis about the experience of Citizen users, their safety concerns, and how the affordances of the app affect users’ perceptions of their communities and community members Status and Support Needed: In progress; I would appreciate feedback on the limitations of my current data, and whether more studies are needed in this phase before moving onto phase II.	Goal: Imagine and design sociotechnical approaches to community safety and prototype those approaches with community members Approach: Design research with residents of Atlanta to create prototypes of sociotechnical platforms that align with TJ principles Methods: Interviews and design exercises; speculative design Data: Transcripts, field notes, video/audio recordings, low- and medium-fidelity prototypes Outcomes: An understanding of how different stakeholders’ needs translate into design prototypes; an understanding of how TJ principles translate into design prototypes; high-fidelity prototypes that are ready to evaluate; strengthened community partnerships. Status and Support Needed: In progress; I would appreciate some help selecting methods for Phase II.	Goal: Evaluate whether the prototypes support safety concerns of community members while aligning with TJ principles Approach: Evaluation of sociotechnical platforms by the residents of Atlanta Methods: Technology probes, field studies Data: Survey responses, pre-post interview transcripts, higher-fidelity prototypes Outcomes: Evaluation of how well design meets safety needs while aligning with TJ principles; higher-fidelity prototypes. Status and Support Needed: Not yet started. I could use help with defining the metrics that will be used for evaluation.

how we can build systems that incentivize accountability while acknowledging that we are all complicit in maintaining systems that create and perpetuate harm [22].

2 GOALS OF MY PHD PROGRAM

One goal of my PhD is to leverage TJ principles to re-imagine crime and safety technologies. I plan to do this in three phases: I) identify the affordances in existing crime and safety technologies that can exacerbate harm; II) imagine and prototype new sociotechnical approaches to community safety that organize collective action; and III) evaluate those designs. So far I have begun work on Phase I and Phase II. Progress on these phases is documented below.

2.1 Phase I Progress

I began Phase I in Summer 2021 by looking specifically at Citizen, a location-based crime alert technology. Citizen uses a proprietary AI algorithm to extract data from police radio to create alert notifications, which can be augmented with user-generated videos [6]. Citizen was originally released in 2016 as Vigilante, a platform where users could develop vigilante-style networks to protect themselves from potential offenders. It was banned from the Apple App Store for its potential to incite violence and then re-branded and released as Citizen in 2017 [15].

As of October 2021, I have completed 13 interviews with Citizen users in Atlanta. I have recruited three other graduate and undergraduate students who are interested in this work and together we are starting data analysis. Analysis so far reveals the following two themes:

- **Increased Fear and Awareness.** Participants described the frequency of alerts as both “eye-opening” (P11) and “stressful” (P10). Almost all participants reported that the increased awareness that came with using Citizen was incredibly valuable; P11 shared that he now knows which roads to avoid,

and P8 felt that she knew more about criminal activity in her own neighborhood. At the same time, the frequency of alerts led participants to feel stressed and anxious. P3 commented that her friends and family wanted her to delete the app because it has a negative effect on her mental health, but she felt it was too important for her safety. The frequency of alerts, the increased awareness of crime, and the resulting stress or fear contributed to participants changing their behavior in various ways. Participants started carrying tasers (P10) and guns (P3), buying new technologies like the Amazon Ring security system (P10, P13), and reporting an increased fear of individuals who are homeless (P2), mentally ill (P3), teenagers (P3), and Black (P5).

- **Who Gets to Define “Crime”?** Participants shared that many of the alerts they receive are not relevant to their individual safety. P12 shares that he doesn’t need to know about “a man brandishing a stick” and P6 wishes Citizen would learn which alerts are most relevant. P2 shares that she doesn’t need to know about “every single alert”. Even if participants knew that the alerts weren’t relevant, an indiscriminate awareness of where crimes occur seemed to change how participants moved through the city. Multiple participants reported changing their walking routine (P2, P3), P4 shared that she no longer frequents a neighborhood where she used to regularly attend art walks, and P8 said that he’s paying attention to Citizen as he decides where to buy a house. P3 reports that she is so anxious by what she’s seeing on Citizen that she is planning to leave the city once her lease ends. Some participants, however, were more critical of what they were seeing on the app. P10 shared that she has no idea who is posting nor what their motivations are. She questions whether what she sees on Citizen is more of a reflection of what seems sensational or “out-of-place” rather than what is actually a threat to her safety.

My next steps for Phase I include further analysis of the data and then writing a paper which I plan to submit to the ACM conference on Computer-Supported Cooperative Work (CSCW). I would like to get feedback from the DC about limitations of my current data as I begin co-designing prototypes in Phase II.

2.2 Phase II Progress

I rely on calls from the Design Justice movement to center the voices of those who are typically marginalized in designing for safety [8]. Towards this aim, I plan to use participatory approaches to design with the houseless community in Atlanta, GA, where I live. In 2019, Atlanta had the second largest inequality gap in the country [2], with 20% of the population living below the poverty line [2]. A survey collection by the City Continuum of Care counted roughly 3200 unhoused individuals, 88% of whom are Black [13]. Participatory work with communities that I am not a member of requires building relationships and demonstrating commitments by “being there” for longer time frames [14]. To start that process, I have begun volunteering and interning with three organizations in Atlanta that serve the houseless community: Gateway Center, a transitional home for formerly incarcerated men, StandUp for

Kids, a street outreach program for houseless youth, and the Policing Alternative and Diversion Initiative (PAD), a harm-reduction program that diverts those who are at risk of arrest towards social services.

My next step is to begin developing a study design for Phase II. I could use support from the DC on selecting methods for this phase. I would like to select methods that are sensitive to the issues of race, equity, access, and power. I would also like to ensure that the prototypes and design process are guided by the principles of TJ. I’m currently exploring participatory methods that would meet these requirements, but would greatly appreciate feedback from DC participants.

Although I have not yet started on Phase III, I realize it is important to start thinking about the metrics with which to evaluate these prototypes even as I’m beginning Phase II. I would greatly benefit from a discussion about processes I can use to select metrics for evaluation.

2.3 Positionality

I am a Brown woman from a socioeconomically advantaged class. I am an Atlanta native, but I am not a member of the houseless communities with whom I hope to work. I am also a PhD student with pressures from my institution around funding and timelines. Given these factors, there is potential for my work to perpetuate rather than dismantle inequities. I plan to spend a substantial amount of time building trust and relationships before collecting any data. I have begun building relationships with staff at the Gateway Center, StandUp for Kids, and PAD. I plan to consult staff at these organizations as I design the study to ensure that my approach is not subjecting participants to undue risk. If there are more ideas that members of the colloquium have about how to ensure that this work is conducted ethically, I would be grateful.

3 CONCLUSION

By the end of my PhD, I hope to have designed and evaluated a sociotechnical system that organizes collective action towards the goal of building safer communities by centering the needs of the houseless population in Atlanta. My long-term goals include working as a researcher-teacher-activist at an organization like Critical Resistance, an Oakland-based abolitionist organization that aims to build safe, healthy, and just communities.

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